Robert had sent rejoinders to the media, but the charges just wouldn't go away. The fact that many of his windfall profits had been acquired from deals in Congress-ruled states like Haryana and Rajasthan was a reality he could not escape from. He simply needed to answer more searching questions. Till he is willing to do so, Vadra will remain a cross that Priyanka will have to live with if she ever enters electoral politics. Already, his name painted on every security-exemption list at airports had enraged the aam janata as a symbol of undeserving VIP privilege.

The Priyanka factor meant that, for a few days at least of the election campaign, the media gaze appeared to shift from Modi. When I interviewed Amit Shah later, he caustically remarked, 'Priyanka may be good for your TRPs, she will have no impact on this election.'

On 2 May, Shah made a sudden visit to Amethi to review the campaign. The feedback he got astounded him. Smriti, with her oratory and boundless energy, was making rapid gains. The general feeling was that the party had a real chance to cause a big upset in the constituency. 'We really felt it was a *kaante ki takkar* [tough fight],' says Sudhanshu Mittal, one of the BJP leaders who had based himself in Amethi.

An excited Shah rang up Modi. 'I think you should do one rally in Amethi also. It could be just what we need to spring a surprise.' Amethi had not been on Modi's original itinerary—there had been a tacit understanding among the Opposition to avoid a direct conflict with the Gandhis. Modi, though, was itching for a fight.

The 5th of May was the last day for campaigning in Amethi. That was the day Modi decided to make his late charge into Rahul's turf by cancelling another scheduled public meeting. Almost overnight, an ad film detailing Amethi's woes was prepared (see chapter 7). Shah asked the RSS–VHP–BJP local leaders to galvanize the cadres from the neighbouring areas. On the ground, Smriti's workers reached out to as many villages as possible. Trucks and Boleros were loaded with expectant crowds. 'Let's give it our best shot—we have nothing to lose,' Shah told his team.

Modi's speech in Amethi was probably his fiercest attack ever on the Gandhi parivar. Each line dripped with anger and sarcasm. 'For forty years,